

LECTURE 3

Business Message Writing Process



EMBA 501
Business Communication
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Learning Objectives:

1. The **three-step writing process**.
2. Understanding **planning** the message.
3. Understanding **writing** the message.
4. Understanding **completing** the message.

Three-Step Writing Process:

By following a **proven process**, you can learn to **create successful messages that meet audience needs and highlight your skills as a business professional**. Use the three-step writing process to ensure that your messages are both effective and efficient.

The three-step writing process consists of-

- **Planning**
- **Writing**
- **Completing the messages.**

Three-Step Writing Process:

1

Plan



2

Write



3

Complete

Analyze the Situation

Define your purpose and develop an audience profile.

Gather Information

Determine audience needs and obtain the information necessary to satisfy those needs.

Choose Medium and Channel

Identify the best combination for the situation, message, and audience.

Organize the Information

Define your main idea, limit your scope, select the direct or indirect approach, and outline your content.

Adapt to Your Audience

Be sensitive to audience needs by using a “you” attitude, politeness, positive emphasis, and unbiased language. Build a strong relationship with your audience by establishing your credibility and projecting your company’s preferred image. Control your style with a conversational tone, plain English, and appropriate voice.

Compose the Message

Choose strong words that will help you create effective sentences and coherent paragraphs.

Revise the Message

Evaluate content and review readability; edit and rewrite for conciseness and clarity.

Produce the Message

Use effective design elements and suitable layout for a clean, professional appearance.

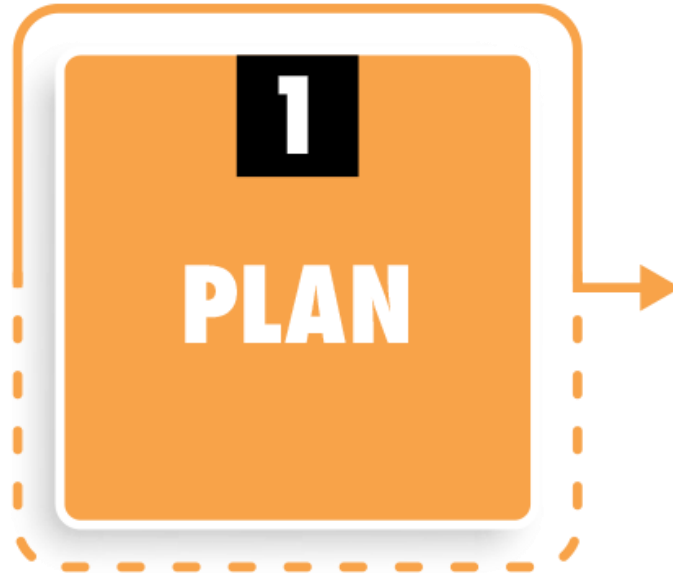
Proofread the Message

Review for errors in layout, spelling, and mechanics.

Distribute the Message

Deliver your message using the chosen channel; make sure all documents and all relevant files are distributed successfully.

Planning the Message



Three-Step Writing Process:

Analyzing the Situation

A successful message starts with a **clear purpose** that connects the sender's needs with the **audience's needs**.

1. Defining Your Purpose:

- All business messages have a **general purpose**: to inform, to persuade, or to collaborate with your audience.
- Business messages also have a **specific purpose**: to help you define the specific purpose of your message, ask yourself what you hope to accomplish with your message and what your audience should do or think after receiving your message.

General Purpose	Specific Purpose
To Inform	Your Goals
To Persuade	Audience Actions
To Collaborate	Audience Thoughts

Three-Step Writing Process:

Analyzing the Situation

2. Profiling Your Audience:

The more you know about your audience, their needs, and their expectations, the more effectively you will be able to communicate with them. Analyzing your audience involves the following steps:

- **Identify the primary audience.**
- **Determine the size of your audience.**
- **Determine the composition of the audience** (same culture/education/race/religion).
- **Gauge your audience's level of understanding.**
- **Project your audience's expectations and preferences.**
- **Estimate your audience's probable reaction.**

Channel & Medium:

Selecting the right medium

- **A medium is the form through which you choose to communicate a message.**
- You may choose to talk with someone face to face, post to a blog, send an email message, or create a webcast.
- **The range of media possibilities is wide and growing wider all the time.**
- Selecting the best medium for your message can make the difference between effective and ineffective communication.
- Although media categories have become increasingly blurred in recent years, for the sake of discussion, you can think of media as being **oral, written, visual, or electronic** (which often combines several media types).

Channel & Medium:

Selecting the right medium

1. Oral Communication

- Primary oral media include **face-to-face conversations, interviews, speeches, and in-person presentations and meetings.**
- By giving communicators, the ability to see, hear, and react to each other, traditional oral media are useful for encouraging people to ask questions, make comments, and work together to reach a consensus or decision.
- Of course, if you do not want a lot of questions or interaction, oral media can be an unwise choice. However, consider the audience carefully before deciding to limit interaction by choosing a different medium.

Channel & Medium:

Selecting the right medium

2. Written Communication

- Written media take many forms, **from traditional memos to glossy reports that rival magazines in production quality.**
- Even though electronic media have replaced many printed messages, the print medium still has a place in business today.
- **Memos are used for the routine, day-to-day exchange of information within an organization.** Because of their open format and informal method of delivery, memos are less private than letters.
- **Letters are written messages sent to recipients outside the organization.** In addition to conveying a particular message, they perform an important public relations function in fostering good working relationships with customers, suppliers, and others.
- **Reports and proposals are usually longer than memos and letters,** although both can be created in memo or letter format. These documents come in a variety of lengths, ranging from a few pages to several hundred, and are usually formal in tone.

Channel & Medium:

Selecting the right medium

3. Visual Communication

- Traditional business messages rely primarily on text, with occasional support from graphical elements such as charts, graphs, or diagrams to help illustrate points discussed in the text. However, **many business communicators are discovering the power of messages in which the visual element is dominant and supported by small amounts of text.**
- For the purposes of this discussion, you can think of visual media as any format in which one or more visual elements play a central role in conveying the message content. Messages that combine powerful **visuals with supporting text can be effective for a number of reasons:**
 - Today's audiences are pressed for time and bombarded with messages, so anything that **communicates quickly** is welcome.
 - **Visuals are also effective at describing complex ideas** and processes because they can reduce the work required for an audience to identify the parts and relationships that make up the whole.
 - In a multilingual business world, diagrams, symbols, and other images can **lower communication barriers** by requiring less language processing.
 - **Visual images can be easier to remember** than purely textual descriptions or explanations.

Channel & Medium:

Selecting the right medium

4. Electronic Communication

When you want to make a powerful impression, using electronic media can increase excitement and visual appeal with computer animation, video, and music. Here is a quick overview of the major electronic media now used in business:

- **Electronic versions of oral media** include telephone calls, teleconferencing (when three or more people join the same call), voicemail messages, and audio recordings such as compact discs and podcasts.
- **Electronic versions of written media** range from email and instant messages to blogs, websites, and wikis.
- **Electronic versions of visual media** can include electronic presentations, computer animation, and video.

The growth of electronic communication options is both a blessing and a curse for business communicators. On the one hand, you have more tools than ever before to choose from, with more ways to deliver business messages. On the other hand, the sheer range of choices can complicate your job because you often need to choose among multiple media and you need to know how to use each medium successfully.

Channel & Medium:

Choosing the Medium

When choosing a medium for your message, consider how your message is affected by the following factors:

1. **Media richness.** This is a medium's ability to (1) convey a message through more than one informational cue, (2) facilitate feedback, and (3) establish personal focus. The richest medium is face-to-face communication.
2. **Message formality.** Your choice of media governs the style and tone of your message. For example, a printed letter is likely to be perceived as a more formal gesture than an email message.
3. **Media limitations.** Every medium has limitations. For instance, IM is perfect for communicating simple, straightforward messages, but it is ineffective for sending complex messages.
4. **Urgency.** Some media establish a connection with the audience faster than others, so choose wisely if your message is urgent. If a message is not urgent, choose a medium that allows people to respond at their convenience.

Channel & Medium:

Choosing the Medium

When choosing a medium for your message, consider how your message is affected by the following factors:

5. **Cost.** This is both a real factor and a perceived nonverbal signal. Distributing an interactive multimedia report on DVD is more costly than attaching an MS Word version of the report to an email message. While a prospective customer may expect a multimedia presentation, your manager would question the cost-effectiveness of such media for routine internal reports.
6. **Audience preferences.** Make sure to consider which media your audience expects or prefers. For example, the United States, Canada, and Germany emphasize written messages. In contrast, Japan emphasizes oral messages—perhaps because its high-context culture carries so much of the message in nonverbal cues and “between-the-lines” interpretation.

Organizing Information:

Information organization in your message can make the difference between effective or ineffective communications. Avoid common mistakes: taking too long to get to the point, including irrelevant material, getting ideas mixed up, and leaving out necessary information.

Good organization helps your audience in several ways:

1. **Helps them understand your message.** By making your main point clear at the outset, your well-organized message will satisfy your audience's need for information.
2. **Helps them accept your message.** Even when your message is logical, you need to select and organize your points in a diplomatic way.
3. **Saves them time.** Well-organized messages are efficient. They contain only relevant ideas, and they are brief.
4. In addition to saving time and energy for your readers, **good organization saves you time and consumes less of your creative energy.** Furthermore, good organizational skills are good for your career because they help you develop a reputation as a clear thinker who cares about your reader.

Organizing Information:

How to achieve good organization?

Understanding the need for good organization is half the battle and knowing to organize your messages well is the other half. While writing a message you can achieve good organization by:

- 1. Defining the main idea**
- 2. Limiting the scope**
- 3. Establishing their sequence by selecting either a direct or indirect approach**

Organizing Information:

How to achieve good organization?

1. Defining the main idea

The topic of your message is the overall subject, and your main idea is a specific statement about that topic.

2. Limiting the Scope:

- The scope of a message is the range of information it presents, its overall length, and the level of detail.
- Limit the scope of your message so that you can convey your main idea as briefly as possible.

3. Choosing the Approach:

- After you've defined your main idea and supporting points, you're ready to decide on the **sequence** you will use to present your information. You have **two basic options**:
 - i. The **direct approach** starts with the main idea (such as a recommendation, a conclusion, or a request) and follows that with supporting points and evidence.
 - ii. The **indirect approach** starts with reasoning, evidence, and background information and builds up to the main idea.

Organizing Information:

Outlining the contents: Outlining saves time and helps you create more effective messages.

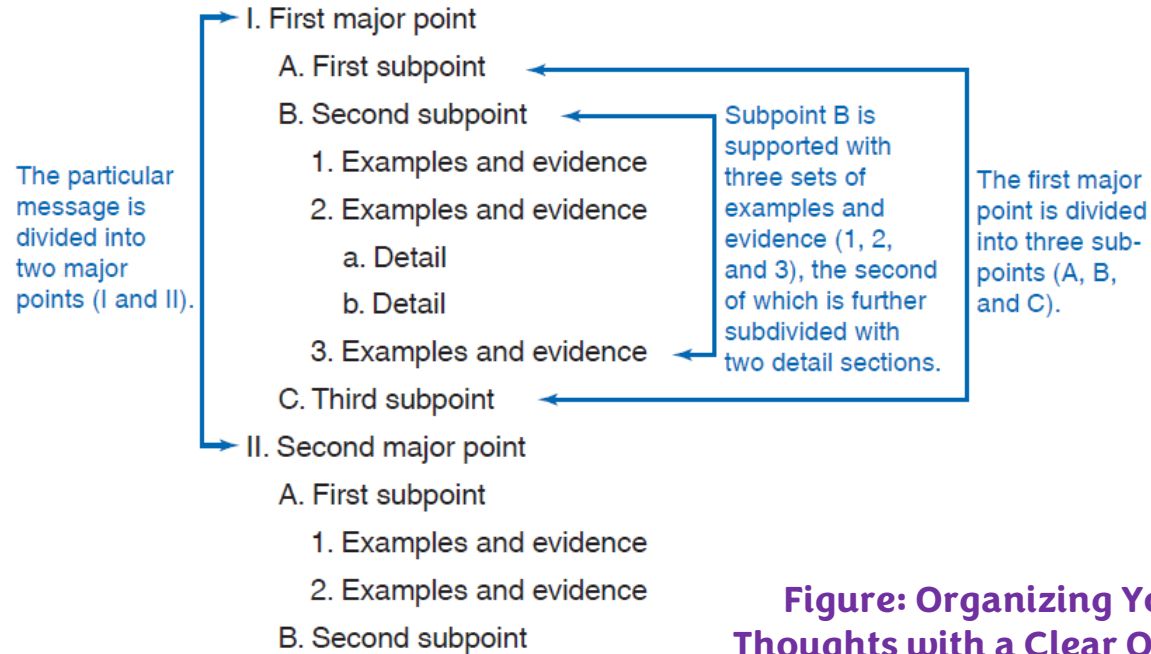


Figure: Organizing Your Thoughts with a Clear Outline

Writing the Message



Being Sensitive to Audience Needs:

- **Readers and listeners are more likely to respond positively when they believe messages address their concerns.**
- Four aspects of being sensitive to audience needs when writing business messages:
 1. **Using the “YOU” attitude**
 2. **Maintaining standards of etiquette**
 3. **Emphasizing the positive**
 4. **Using bias-free language**

Being Sensitive to Audience Needs:

1. Using the “YOU” attitude:

- Adopting the “you” attitude means speaking and writing in terms of your audience’s wishes, interests, hopes, and preferences.
- On the simplest level, you can adopt the “you” attitude by replacing terms such as **I, me, mine, we, us, and ours with you and yours.**

Instead of This

Tuesday is the only day that we can promise quick response to purchase order requests. We are swamped the rest of the week.

At Construction Resources, we are proud to supply the highest-rated engineered wood in the entire Midwest.

Write This

If you need a quick response, please submit your purchase order requests on Tuesday.

Ensure the integrity of your building projects with the highest-rated engineered wood in the entire Midwest.

- Be aware that on some occasions, it’s better to avoid using you, particularly if doing so will sound overly authoritative or accusing:

Instead of This

You failed to deliver the customer’s order on time.

You must correct all five copies by noon.

Write This

The customer didn’t receive the order on time.

All five copies must be corrected by noon.

Being Sensitive to Audience Needs:

2. Maintaining standards of etiquette:

- Good etiquette shows respect for your audience and helps foster a more successful environment for communication by minimizing negative emotional reactions.

Instead of This	Write This
Once again, you've managed to bring down the website through your incompetent programming.	Let's review the last website update to explore ways to improve the process.
You've been sitting on our order for two weeks, and we need it now!	Our production schedules depend on timely delivery of parts and supplies, but we have not yet received the order scheduled for delivery two weeks ago. Please respond today with a firm delivery commitment.

- Naturally, some situations require more diplomacy than others. If you know your audience well, a less formal approach may be more appropriate.
- With written communication and most forms of digital communication, pay extra attention to tact.

Being Sensitive to Audience Needs:

3. **Emphasizing the positive:**

- During your career, you will have many occasions in which you need to communicate bad news.
- However, there is a big difference between delivering negative news and being negative.
- Never try to hide negative news but always be on the lookout for positive points that will foster a good relationship with your audience.

Instead of This	Write This
It is impossible to repair your laptop today.	Your computer can be ready by Tuesday. Would you like a loaner until then?
We wasted \$300,000 advertising in that magazine.	Our \$300,000 advertising investment did not pay off; let's analyze the experience and apply the insights to future campaigns.

Being Sensitive to Audience Needs:

3. Emphasizing the positive:

- If you find it necessary to criticize or correct, don't dwell on the other person's mistakes.
- Avoid referring to failures, problems, or shortcomings. Focus instead on what the audience members can do to improve the situation.

Instead of This	Write This
The problem with this department is a failure to control costs.	The performance of this department can be improved with tighter cost controls.
You failed to provide all the necessary information on the previous screen.	Please review the items marked in red so that we can process your order as quickly as possible.

- If you're trying to persuade audience members to buy a product, pay a bill, or perform a service for you, emphasize what's in it for them.
- When people recognize the benefits of doing so, they are more likely to respond positively to your appeal:

Instead of This	Write This
We will notify all three credit reporting agencies if you do not pay your overdue bill within 10 days.	Paying your overdue bill within 10 days will prevent a negative entry on your credit record.
I am tired of seeing so many errors in the customer service blog.	Proofreading your blog posts will help avoid embarrassing mistakes that erode confidence in our ability to help customers.

Being Sensitive to Audience Needs:

4. **Using bias-free language:**

- Bias-free language avoids words and phrases that unfairly and even unethically categorize or stigmatize people.
- **Bias can come in a variety of forms:**
 1. **Gender bias.**
 2. **Racial and ethnic bias**
 3. **Age bias**
 4. **Disability bias**

Composing your message:

Controlling Your Style and Tone:

- **Style** is the way you use words to achieve a certain tone, or overall impression. The right choice depends on the nature of your message and your audience.
- Most business messages aim for a **conversational tone**, using plain language.
- **Plain language** is a way of writing and arranging technical materials so that your audience can understand your meaning. Because it is close to the way people normally speak, plain language is easy to understand.
- Your choice of **active or passive voice** also affects the tone of your message. Using the active voice produces shorter, stronger sentences and makes your writing more vigorous, concise, and generally easier to understand.

Composing your message:

A. Conversational Tone:

You can achieve a conversational tone in your business messages by following these guidelines:

- **Texting versus writing.** The casual, acronym-laden language used in text messaging and IM between friends is not considered professional business writing.
- **Avoid stale and pompous language.** Business language used to be much more formal than it is today, and some out-of-date phrases still remain. You can avoid using such language if you ask yourself, “Would I say this if I were talking with someone face-to-face?” Furthermore, avoid trying to impress others by using big words, trite expressions, and overly complicated sentences. Such pompous language sounds pretentious.
- **Avoid preaching and bragging.** Few things are more irritating than people who think that they know everything and that others know nothing.
- **Be careful with intimacy.** Most business messages should avoid intimacy, such as sharing personal details or adopting a causal, unprofessional tone
- **Be careful with humor.** Humor can be an effective tool to inject interest into dry subjects or take the sting out of negative news. However, use it with great care, and remember that the humor must be connected to the point you are trying to make.

Composing your message:

B. Using Plain Language:

- Plain language is a way of presenting information in a simple, unadorned style so that your audience can easily grasp your meaning without struggling through specialized, technical, or convoluted language.
- The Plain English Campaign (a nonprofit group in England campaigning for clear language) defines plain English as language “that the intended audience can read, understand and act upon the first time they read it.”
- You can see how this definition supports using the “you” attitude and shows respect for your audience.
- In addition, plain language can make companies more productive and more profitable simply because people spend less time trying to figure out messages that are confusing or that are not written to meet their needs.

Composing your message:

C. Using the Right Voice:

- Your choice of active or passive voice also affects the tone of your message.
- You are using **active voice** when the subject (“actor”) comes before the verb, and the object (“acted upon”) comes after the verb: for example, “Joe rented the car.”
- You are using **passive voice** when the subject follows the verb and the object precedes it: for example, “The car was rented by Joe.”
- Use the active voice to produce shorter, stronger sentences and make your writing more vigorous, concise, and generally easier to understand.
- The passive voice is not wrong grammatically, but it is often cumbersome or unnecessarily vague, and it can make sentences longer.
- Nevertheless, using the passive voice can help you demonstrate the “you” attitude in some situations:
 - i. When you want to be diplomatic about pointing out a problem or error of some kind
 - ii. When you want to point out what is being done without taking or attributing either the credit or the blame
 - iii. When you want to avoid personal pronouns in order to create an objective tone.

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Completing the Message



A. Revising Your Message:

- The **revision task** can vary somewhat, **depending on the medium and the nature of your message.**
- For informal messages to internal audiences via electronic media, the revision process is often as simple as quickly looking over your message to correct mistakes before sending or posting it.
- However, do not fall into the common trap of thinking that the fundamentals of good writing are unimportant.
- These qualities can be even more important in electronic media, particularly if these messages are the only contact your audience has with you.
- With more complex messages, try to put your draft aside for a day or two before you begin the revision process so that you can approach the material with a fresh eye.
- Then, start with the “big picture,” making sure that the document accomplishes your overall goals before moving to finer points such as readability, clarity, and conciseness.

Evaluating Your First Draft:

- After you have completed a first draft, you may be tempted to breathe a sigh of relief, send the message on its way, and move on to the next project. **Resist this temptation!**
- Successful communicators recognize that the first draft is rarely as tight, clear, and compelling as it needs to be.
- **Careful revision** can mean the difference between a rambling, unfocused message and a lively, direct message that gets results.
- The third step of the three-step writing process involves four key tasks: **revising your message and then producing, proofreading, and distributing it.**

Evaluating Your Message:

- To evaluate the content of your message, answer these questions:
 - **Is the information accurate?**
 - **Is the information relevant to the audience?**
 - **Is there enough information to satisfy the readers' needs?**
 - **Is there a good balance between general information** (giving readers enough background information to appreciate the message) **and specific information** (giving readers the details they need to understand the message)?
- When you are satisfied with the content of your message, you can review its organization. Answer another set of questions:
 - **Are all the points covered in the most logical order?**
 - **Do the most important ideas receive the most space, and are they placed in the most prominent positions?**
 - **Would the message be more convincing if it were arranged in another sequence?**
 - **Are any points repeated unnecessarily?**
 - **Are details grouped together logically, or are some still scattered throughout the document?**
- Next, consider whether you have achieved the right tone for your audience. Is your writing formal enough to meet the audience's expectations without being too formal or academic? Is it too casual for a serious subject?

Revising to Improve Readability:

- After checking the content, organization, style, and tone of your message, make a second pass to improve readability.
- Beyond using **shorter words and simpler sentences**, you can improve the readability of a message by making the document **interesting and easy to skim**.
- Most business audiences—particularly influential senior managers—tend to skim documents looking for key ideas, conclusions, and recommendations.
- If they determine that a document contains valuable information or requires a response, they will read it more carefully when time permits.
- **Four techniques will make your message easier to read and easier to skim:**
 - i. Varying sentence length.
 - ii. Using shorter paragraphs.
 - iii. Using lists and bullets instead of narrative.
 - iv. Adding effective headings and subheadings.

B. Producing the Message:

- **Design affects readability in two important ways.**
- First, if done carefully, design elements can improve the effectiveness of your message. If done poorly, design elements can act as barriers, blocking your communication.
- Second, the visual design itself sends a nonverbal message to your readers, influencing their perceptions of the communication before they read a single word.
- Effective design guides your readers through your message, so **be sure that your business documents are based on the following elements:**
- **Consistency.** Throughout a message, be consistent in your use of margins, typeface, type size, and spacing. Also be consistent when using recurring design elements, such as vertical lines, columns, and borders.
- **Balance.** To create a pleasing design, balance all visual elements, including text, artwork, and white space.
- **Detail.** Pay attention to details that affect your design and thus your message.
- **Restraint.** Strive for simplicity in design. Do not clutter your message with too many design elements, too much highlighting, or too many decorative touches.

B. Producing the Message:

- By improving the appearance of your documents, you will improve your readers' impressions of you and your messages. The following are **some production technology features** that you can use:
 1. **Templates and style sheets.**
 2. **Page setup.**
 3. **Column formatting.**
 4. **Paragraph formatting.**
 5. **Numbered and bulleted lists.**
 6. **Tables. Images, text boxes, and objects.**

C. Proofreading Your Message:

- Look for two types of problems:
 - (1) undetected mistakes from the writing, design, and layout stages.
 - (2) mistakes that crept in during production, anything from computer glitches such as missing fonts to broken web links to problems with the ink used in printing.
- Be particularly vigilant with complex documents and complex production processes that involve teams of people and multiple computers.
- Strange things can happen as files move from computer to computer, especially when many fonts and multimedia elements are involved.

D. Distributing Your Message:

- With the production phase finished, you are ready to distribute the message.
- As with every other aspect of business communication, your options for distribution multiply with every advance in technology.
- **When planning for distribution, consider the following factors:**
 1. **Cost.** This is not a concern for most messages, but for lengthy reports or multimedia production, it might well be. Printing, binding, and delivering reports can be an expensive proposition, so weigh the cost versus the benefits before you decide.
 2. **Convenience.** How much work is involved for you and your audience? Although it is easy to attach a document to an email message, things might not be so simple for the people on the other end.
 3. **Time.** How soon does the message need to reach the audience? Do not waste money on overnight delivery if the recipient will not read the report for a week.
 4. **Security and privacy.** The convenience offered by IM, email, and other technologies needs to be weighed against security and privacy concerns.
- Distribution technologies continue to advance, so be on the lookout for new ways to put your messages into the hands of your audience.

THE END.

